A GUIDE TO...

HOMONYMS HOMOPHONES & HOMOGRAPHS



COMMA CHAMELEON

HOMONYMS

The suffix 'nym' means 'name'. Homonyms are words that are spelled the same (like homographs) and pronounced the same (like homophones), but have different meanings. Here are some of the most common ones:

Address
1. To speak to
2. A location

Air
1. The mixture of gases in the environment
2. An impression of a quality or manner given by someone

Arm
1. The upper limb of a human body
2. A division or branch of a company
3. To kit one out with weaponry

Band
1. A musical group
2. A flat, thin loop of material

Bark
1. A tree's outer layer
2. The sound a dog makes

Bat
1. An implement used for hitting a ball
2. A nocturnal flying mammal

Bright
1. Very smart or intelligent
2. Giving out or reflecting a lot of light

Circular
1. Taking the form of a circle
2. A newsletter distributed to a lot of people

Current
1. Up to date
2. The flow of water or electricity

Die
1. To cease living
2. A cube marked with numbers 1 to 6

Express
1. Something done fast
2. To convey one's thoughts or feelings with words

Fair
1. Equitable
2. Beautiful

Kind
1. A group of people/things having similar characteristics
2. Caring in nature or action

Lie
1. To recline
2. To tell a falsehood

Match
1. To pair similar items
2. A stick for making a flame
3. A sporting contest

Mean
1. The average
2. Not nice, unkind

Pound
1. A unit of weight
2. To hit repeatedly

Ring
1. A metal band, worn on a finger
2. Something circular in shape

Right
1. Correct
2. The direction that is the opposite of left

Rock
1. A genre of music
2. A large stone

Rose
1. The past tense of rise
2. A prickly bush or shrub that bears flowers

Spring
1. One of the four seasons
2. A coil of metal

Stalk
1. A part of a plant
2. To follow stealthily

Tender
1. With gentleness
2. An offer to carry out work or supply goods
3. To present something formally

Tire
1. To grow fatigued
2. A part of a wheel

HOMOPHONES

The suffix 'phone' relates to sound. When you talk on the telephone, you hear the other person's voice. And phonology is the study of a language's sounds. So 'homophone' means 'same sound', and these words are pronounced the same. Here are some common ones:

brake / break
Example: When driving at night, it's important to hit the brake and take a break.

cell / sell
Example: If you sell drugs, you might get arrested and end up in a prison cell.

sent / scent
Example: The flowers I sent my teacher had an incredible scent.

die / dye
Example: If you drank a bottle of fabric dye, you might die.

flour / flower
Example: The recipe calls for flour and an edible flower.

for / four
Example: I bought four ice creams for just £2.

heal / heel
Example: I broke my heel once, and it took about four months to properly heal.

hear / here
Example: I wanted to sit here so I could hear the band better.

hour / our
Example: We have one hour before our flight departs.

idle / idol
Example: Being idle makes me nothing like my idol, Einstein.

knight / night
Example: The knight fought all the more fiercely at night.

knot / not
Example: I do not know how to tie a reef knot.

poor / pour
Example: I pour drinks for a living, but I'm quite poor at it.

right / write
Example: There is no right way to write a great novel.

sea / see
Example: I love to wake up and see the sea.

sole / soul
Example: The sole reason for her kindness is her gentle soul.

son / sun
Example: My son loves to spend time outside in the sun.

steal / steel
Example: The girders were made of steel, and some reprobate decided to steal them.

tail / tale
Example: My dog chasing his tail is a tale my kids love to hear.

weather / whether
Example: The weather looks changeable today. I don't know whether to bring a rain mac or a thick coat.

OFT-CONFUSED HOMOPHONES

These homophones frequently get confused:

accept/except:
Accept is a verb that means to take or receive. **Except** is used as a preposition or conjunction to mean but or exclude.

affect/effect:
Affect is a verb and indicates an influence. **Effect** is a noun (in most cases) and is the result of an action or change.

compliment/complement:
Compliment means to say something nice about someone or something. **Complement** means something that enhances something else.

then/than:
Then is a versatile word used as an adverb, noun or adjective to show the order of how things happened. **Than** is a subordinating conjunction you can use to make comparisons.

to/too:
To can be a preposition or infinitive when used with a verb. **Too** is an adverb or a synonym for also.

you're/your:
You're is a contraction for you are. **Your** is a pronoun.

HOMOGRAPHS

The suffix 'graph' denotes something written or drawn. The word 'homograph' means 'same picture' or 'same writing', and homographs are words that are spelt the same but pronounced differently. Here are some common ones:

accent
1. Stress or emphasis
2. A manner of speaking or pronunciation influenced by the region in which one lives or grew up

agape
1. Wide open
2. A Greek word meaning 'love'

attribute
1. A characteristic or quality
2. To think of as belonging to or originating in some person, place or thing

bass
1. A deep voice or tone
2. A kind of fish

bow
1. To bend at the waist
2. Ahe front of a boat
3. A pair of tied loops

buffet
1. To hit, punch or slap
2. A self-serve food bar

compact
1. Small
2. To make small
3. A small case for holding make-up

compound
1. To mix or combine
2. An enclosed area with a building or group of buildings inside

content
1. Happy or satisfied
2. All that is contained inside something

contract
1. An agreement
2. To get, acquire or incur

coordinates
1. brings into proper place or order/
2. a set of numbers used to calculate position

desert
1. A hot, arid region
2. To leave

digest
1. A condensed version of some information
2. To change food in the stomach into a form that can be absorbed by the body

discount
1. A reduction in price
2. To give no credence to the significance of something

down
1. In a lower position
2. Soft, furry feathers

entrance
1. The place of entry
2. To bewitch, delight or enrapture

fine
1. Very good
2. Sharp or keen
3. Delicate or subtle
4. A sum of money paid to settle a matter

frequent
1. Occurring regularly
2. To visit a place with regularity

incense
1. A substance that produces a pleasant odour when burned
2. To infuriate or make very angry

lead
1. To go first, with followers behind
2. A type of metal

minute
1. 60 seconds
2. Extremely small

moped
1. Acted sad or gloomy
2. A bicycle with a motor

object
1. A thing you can see or touch
2. To be opposed to

proceeds
1. Advances or continues on
2. The money or profit gained from a sale or venture

produce
1. To create or make
2. Fresh fruits and vegetables

project
1. A plan or proposal
2. To throw or hurl forward
3. To cause a shadow or image to fall upon a surface

number
1. A numeral
2. To count
3. More numb

refuse
1. Waste or garbage
2. To reject or decline to accept

row
1. A fight
2. To propel a boat forward using oars
3. A line

subject
1. Under some authority or control
2. To bring under authority or control
3. To make liable or vulnerable
4. A topic
5. The noun in a sentence about which something is said in the predicate

tear
1. To rip
2. A drop of water from the eye

wind
1. To turn
2. Moving air

wound
1. Turned
2. An injury